

GENDER

Anashree Vs. Krish



Unless you're an incorrigible Virgo, you'll see a mess of files when you open folders on your computer. So that was our set task: sorting documents from the loads of them we had. We wanted to look at how Anashree and Krish approached the sorting "problem." Are women's computers better organised? Like a kitchen? That's where we got this idea...

BENDERS

One look at all the mess, and she sank bank in her seat. Resolve took over, and Anashree took but a couple of seconds to run through all the files in the horribly-organised folder. First folder: Songs. All songs moved into there. Looking for file types, she dumped all the music files into the aforementioned Songs folder. She went on to create folders called Applications, Games, and Video, and performed the boring but requisite task. "Documents" now contained PDF, Word, and text formats; but within them were recipes, computer-related files, and jokes, which Anashree didn't seem to have noticed. Documents were still somewhat of a mess.



Both Krish and Anashree neglected to sort files beyond the file formats: video files contained movies, trailers, and small video clips, which could have been categorised better. Also, it's easy to sort files using Arrange Icons By > Type. They hadn't even got that part. Dismal in the end.



Unlike Anashree, Krish didn't bother with reading the filenames. Glancing through file types, he created folders called Pictures, Sounds, Word Documents, Appz, and Video. This done, he started searching for the appropriate icons, and dumped them into the categories.

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together was "to offer their users privacy from unknown users and security from IM viruses." The interoperability would benefit users, the industry, and the business of the behemoths. No-one smelt anything else brewing back then.

Back then, preliminary talks took place between them for a merger, but resulted in nothing. At that time, Microsoft was using Yahoo!'s search and advertising system, then they started their own. This year, in the first week of May, the news was all over on the Web, first posted at

the *New York Post*: Microsoft's willingness to buy Yahoo! and Goldman Sachs' helping Microsoft with the deal.

Within a few hours, the closing trade figures for Yahoo! indicated a rise by 9.9 per cent at the end of the day after reports about the possible tie-up were published. The amount quoted by Microsoft to buy Yahoo! was roughly \$50 billion. *The Wall Street Journal* reported that the companies weren't merging, but that talks were in the early stages, and that both were looking at a strategic partnership. The talks began and stopped a few times, but

neither shared any details. Many said the news was highly speculative and a mere rumour blown out of proportion. Yet firm theories are now being formulated about the reasons for Microsoft being eager to merge with Yahoo!.

One of the reasons is the DoubleClick buyout by Google, which Microsoft wanted to include under their umbrella. Then, Google earns more from advertising than Microsoft does, and to catch up with them, Microsoft recently bought aQuantive, an online advertising and marketing firm. In terms of search engine advertising, Yahoo! scores over Microsoft, though below Google. Yahoo! released its new search advertising system, "Panama," in December 2006.

At one end, Google is aggressively beating Microsoft not only in advertising but also with their upcoming online office applications. Google is working on an online software service to compete with Microsoft Office. Yahoo!, though smaller, is also a better brand compared to MSN in terms of advertising networks.

It's crystal-clear that Microsoft needs Yahoo! more than Yahoo! needs Microsoft. If they merge, they would be an advertising behemoth. Also, Yahoo! can have the technical expertise of the software giant. Interestingly, in the nascent years of Google, Yahoo! offered to buy them at \$3 billion, but Google had other plans. Today, Google's market

value (\$147 billion) is almost four times Yahoo's market value (\$38 billion), whereas Microsoft (\$296 billion) outweighs both of them.

The details of the closed-door talks have not been available to the media thus far—neither Yahoo! nor Microsoft personnel are willing to say anything. Ballmer is definitely not pleased with Microsoft's Web presence. Yet, whether Microsoft or Yahoo! will tie-up in any way is uncertain—naturally. What's gotten us all alert is the very fact that the talks happened, even if behind closed doors.

IT'S NOW REAL-TIME

Trends And Zeitgeist Merge

For most, Google is the ultimate search destination. According to a recent study by Nielsen/NetRatings, Google accounted for 55.2 per cent of Web searches; Google remains Search King, and probably will for some time to come.

In a recent *Fast Track*, we've told you about Google Trends, which is a good analysis tool to help you find out the latest, well, trends in search terms. For example, to find out—in accordance with the trends—which is the more popular between the iPod and the Zune, enter both terms in www.google.com/trends, and you get a search volume graph for analysis. Now, if you want

Microsoft Silverlight

Microsoft's Silverlight, the alleged "Adobe Flash killer," is the new plugin platform for delivery of rich interactive media applications on the Web. It is currently available on Windows (Vista and XP) and Mac OS X (10.4.8 and later), supported by three browsers—Internet Explorer, Firefox, and Safari.

High Definition (720p) content will also get better delivery support with WMV, and Silverlight brings the SMPTE (Society of Motion Picture and Television

Engineers) VC-1 standard to the Web. Silverlight Streaming Services has also been announced, wherein users and developers can host Silverlight content. A Linux version will be developed by Mono, an open-source development platform for the .NET Framework.

Whether Silverlight will gain ground over Adobe's Flash and other solutions for delivery of rich media experience will be known only after the release of the final version.

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